

AIDS

HIV is a virus that weakens the body's defences. It cannot be cured, but treatment lets people with HIV stay healthy for many years. Testing and treatment are free.

For community members

Key messages

- HIV spreads through sex without a condom, through blood (shared needles or razors), and from a mother to her baby in pregnancy, birth or breastfeeding.
- HIV does not spread by hugging, sharing food or plates, using the same toilet, or mosquito bites.
- You can get tested at the health centre. Knowing your status helps you protect yourself and your family.
- HIV medicine (ART) is life-long and free at ART sites. Taking it every day keeps the virus low.

- All pregnant women should be tested for HIV and syphilis at antenatal care. A mother who takes her medicine, gives birth at the facility, and gives only breast milk for six months can protect her baby. The baby gets medicine after birth and is tested at 6 weeks.
- Condoms protect against HIV and pregnancy. Do not share needles or razors. Tell your partner to get tested too.
- Do not shame or shut out people with HIV. Support them to stay on treatment. Keep their information private.

Think about getting tested if

- You had sex without a condom or with more than one partner
- You have TB
- You are pregnant
- Your partner has HIV
- You have had a long fever, diarrhoea or weight loss with no clear reason

General information only. Follow the advice of your health centre and current national guidelines. Based on

the National Department of Health Village Health Assistant (VHA) training curriculum.